

R

RANGE (1) The geographical distribution of a particular species. (2) The “home range” of an individual animal is the area within which it normally forages, which may or may not also be a territory. See also *Territory*. (3) In geology, a term applied to a mountain belt.

RAPTOR A bird of prey.

RUMINANT Cloven-hooved mammals, such as antelope and sheep, that have a specialized digestive system with a compartmented stomach. The first compartment, the rumen, contains microorganisms that help break down tough plant food. It is also regurgitated and rechewed, a process called ruminating or “chewing the cud.”

RUT The breeding season of deer. Also called the rutting season, it is marked by intense rivalry between males for mates. It often involves roaring (“rut” is an old word for roar) and displaying. Equally matched males fight.

S

SALINE Of water, springs, or lakes: having a high concentration of dissolved salts.

SAVANNA A general term for all tropical grasslands. Most savannas also have scattered trees.

SCUTES Shieldlike plates or scales that form a hard covering on some animals.

SEAMOUNT An undersea mountain, usually formed from an extinct volcano.

SEXUAL DIMORPHISM Condition in which the males and females of a species differ obviously in appearance (for example, in color pattern, shape, or size).

SHIELD In geology, any large, stable region of ancient rocks that has not been altered by mountain-building in recent geological history. Shield regions are usually relatively flat and form the central parts of most continents.

SPAWN The eggs of fish, amphibians, and marine invertebrates, especially when laid as a large mass. “To spawn” is to lay such eggs.

SPECIATION The formation of new species.

SPECIES A species is the basic unit of biological classification. It is a group

of organisms that are similar in appearance and behavior, usually breed only with each other, and differ in some way from other similar species.

SPERMATOPHORE A packet of sperm that is transferred either directly from the male to the female, or indirectly—for example, by being left on the ground. Spermatophores are produced by a range of animals, including squid, salamanders, and some insects.

STOOP Of a bird of prey: to swoop down swiftly on its target prey.

STRATIFIED GRAZING The different feeding levels (grasses, bushes, trees) and different parts and ages of plants (new shoots, older plants) eaten by various grazers and browsers in the same area.

STRIDULATE Of insects such as grasshoppers: to make a shrill or grating noise by rubbing modified parts of the body against one another. Some tarantula spiders and venomous snakes also stridulate.

STROBILURIN Any of several related chemical compounds used in agriculture to kill fungi.

SUBDUCTION The sinking of one tectonic plate beneath another when the two plates collide. See *Plate tectonics* and *Midoccean ridge*.

SUBTROPICAL DRY BROADLEAF FORESTS Forests in warm subtropical regions where frost is still occasionally possible and where there is a long dry season, during which trees may shed their leaves.

SYMBIOTIC RELATIONSHIP A close living, relatively long-term relationship between two species. See also *Mutualism*, *Parasite*.

T

TAIGA Another term for boreal forest, though sometimes used just for the northern part of this, nearest the tundra.

TECTONIC PLATE Any of the large, rigid sections into which the Earth’s surface is divided, such as the Pacific Plate.

TEMPERATE Relating to the regions of the Earth between the tropics and the polar regions.

TEMPERATE BROADLEAF FORESTS Forests in temperate regions that are dominated by broadleaf tree species.

TEMPERATE CONIFEROUS FORESTS Evergreen forests, often dominated by

conifers, that occur in temperate regions with warm summers, cold winters, and typically plentiful rainfall.

TERRITORY A particular area or section of habitat defended by an animal or group of animals against rivals, usually of the same species. See also *Range*.

TROPICAL Relating to the warm regions of the Earth that lie between the Equator and the tropics of Cancer (to the north) and Capricorn (to the south).

TROPICAL DRY BROADLEAF FORESTS Tropical broadleaf forests growing in regions with a long dry season.

TROPICAL MOIST BROADLEAF FORESTS Tropical forests dominated by broadleaved trees and characterized by high rainfall and no long dry season.

TUNDRA A treeless habitat of low-growing, cold-tolerant plants widespread in the far north of North America, Russia, and the Antarctic peninsula. A similar habitat (alpine tundra) is found high on some mountain ranges as well.

TUSK In mammals, an enlarged modified tooth that often projects outside the mouth.

TYPHOON A tropical cyclone, especially in Pacific regions (equivalent to a hurricane in the Atlantic).

U

ULTRAVIOLET RADIATION Radiation of shorter wavelength than the light visible to humans, which other animals may be able to see.

UMBRELLA SPECIES A species whose protection and conservation has the side effect of protecting threatened habitats where it lives, and the other animals and plants that live there.

UNGULATE A hooved mammal.

V

VASCULAR PLANT Any plant with specialized tissues for transporting water and nutrients between its different parts. Most land plants except for mosses and their relatives are vascular plants.

VENOM Any toxic fluid produced by an animal that is actively transferred into the body of another. Venomous animals commonly deliver their venom via fangs, stings, or similar structures.

VENTRAL Relating to the lower surface or underside of an animal.

VERTEBRATE Any animal with a backbone (fish, amphibians, reptiles, birds, and mammals). See also *Chordate*, *Invertebrate*.

VIVIPAROUS Giving birth to live young, rather than laying eggs.

W

WARNING COLORATION Striking colors on an animal designed to warn potential predators that it is poisonous or otherwise dangerous.

WEANING The period of adjustment in young mammals’ lives when they start taking solid food rather than relying on their mother’s milk.

WORLD HERITAGE SITE A site designated by the United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) as being of world importance either for cultural reasons (such as historic city centers) or for aspects of its natural heritage, such as its natural beauty, conservation value, or geological interest.

Y

YUNGAS The varied and biodiverse warm, moist broadleaf forests on the eastern side of the Andes mountains.

Z

ZOOPLANKTON Animals such as krill that are part of the plankton. See *Plankton*.

ZYGOMATIC ARCH Bony arch under the eye socket on each side of the face.

The IUCN (International Union for the Conservation of Nature) is the leading source of information on the conservation and status of animal and plant species. Scientists and organizations collect data on a species’ population size, rate of habitat fragmentation and decline, and the IUCN assess the risk for each species using this information.